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Close the loop restaurants' apps leave open

Restaurant operations app: checklists, repairs & maintenance, handbook and food-safety compliance. Competitor landscape, operator pain points, regulations (US/UK), market, and recommended product plan.

> The opportunity is a product for **independent restaurant groups with 1–10 locations**. Today no affordable app gives them all four of the pillars they need: opening/closing and food-safety checklists, repairs and maintenance, an employee handbook with policies, and inspection-ready records. Buyers have absorbed the dedicated vendors one after another. Crunchtime bought Zenput and Squadle, Access bought Trail, and Digi bought Jolt for about $145.5M. Each of those products was then pulled toward enterprise suites. Independents are left with $13-per-location task add-ons, horizontal tools priced per user, single-purpose food-safety apps, or paper. Check65 is not a standalone product to copy. It is the free field app of Food Alert's UK consultancy-plus-software bundle (owned by Citation), and its strength is regulatory content and advisory services, not UX or price. Reviews across Jolt, Crunchtime, SafetyCulture and 7shifts all complain about the same things: slow mobile apps, flaky Bluetooth hardware, contract lock-in, heavy setup, and support that "never fixes anything." Those complaints point to how a new entrant wins. Build it phone-first and offline-first. Make it useful in 15 minutes using templates driven by jurisdiction rules. Make it hard to fake without hardware. Price it per location with unlimited users and month-to-month terms, at roughly **$49–$119 per location per month**. The differentiating feature is a closed loop. A failed check becomes a corrective action, then a work order, then a vendor visit, then a cost and warranty history, and all of it rolls up into an "inspector mode" record. No SMB competitor ties these together. The main risks are that independents churn and are shrinking about 2% a year, that POS platforms are moving up-stack with AI, and that exits in this category have priced at mid-single-digit ARR multiples. Several regulatory details below are flagged **[verify]** because the underlying research could not confirm them against a primary source.

Check65 is a consultancy's field app, and the market around it has split into five camps

Check65 is the mobile companion to **Alert65**, the compliance platform of **Food Alert**, a London food-safety consultancy founded in 1990. The Citation Group bought Food Alert in 2019 and publishes the app as Citation Holdings Limited (App Store; Food Alert). The app covers daily, weekly and monthly checklists (opening/closing, cleaning, fire safety), ad-hoc checklists such as visitor logs, hot, cold and delivery temperature checks, role-based task filtering, a green/amber/red priority score, Bluetooth probes, and offline mode. Alert65 adds the depth behind it: digital HACCP plans, **200+ consultant-written risk assessments**, an allergen matrix, training tracking, certification-deadline monitoring, incident logging, and EHO inspection-readiness tools (Food Alert). Food Alert claims **3,000+ food businesses and 1 million checklists a month**. Pricing is quote-only. The iOS app has only **2 US ratings**, so its distribution comes through enterprise contracts and Citation's HR and health-and-safety cross-sell rather than app-store discovery (App Store). Two things follow. A newcomer will not out-consult Food Alert on UK regulatory content. And Check65's public feature list has no repairs and maintenance workflow, no handbook, no transparent pricing and no self-serve onboarding. Those four gaps are the openings.

The wider market falls into five camps. US multi-unit ops platforms (Jolt, Crunchtime Ops, Xenia, Operandio, Delightree) are mostly quote-based. Food-safety and HACCP specialists (FoodDocs, ComplianceMate/Ladle, Navitas, Food Alert) carry the IoT and HACCP depth. UK checklist apps (Trail, Culinary Key) publish transparent per-site prices. Horizontal tools (SafetyCulture, Connecteam, MaintainX, UpKeep) charge per user or per hub. Scheduling and back-office suites (7shifts, Homebase, Restaurant365) sell tasks as a cheap add-on. AI-first entrants such as Palona ($20M raised, with Din Tai Fung as a customer) and Owner ($240M Series D) are aiming at voice, vision and agents rather than checklists (Restaurant Technology News; Restaurant Business).

Check65 feature by feature: what to match and where to beat it

Food Alert's own product page, "Due diligence in the palm of your hand", describes Check65 as a way to turn paper checklists into one mobile and desktop app (Food Alert). Its listed features are the baseline a new app has to meet:

Check65 feature (per Food Alert)	What it does	Match or beat?
Digital checklists, tasks shown by status in time order	Replaces paper daily, weekly and monthly checks	**Match.** This is table stakes. Beat it with templates set by location rules and setup in under 15 minutes
Food delivery, cold (fridge/freezer/cold holding/cooling/ambient) and hot (cook/reheat/hot hold) checks	Core food-safety due-diligence records	**Match.** Beat it with a guided two-stage cooling timer and flags for repeated identical readings
Corrective actions recorded	Notes what was done when a check fails	**Beat.** Check65 stops at recording the action. Here a failed check becomes a work order on that piece of equipment, sent to a vendor, with the cost and warranty logged
Visitor details	Contractor and visitor log	**Match.** Link each visitor log to the contractor's work order
"Smart dashboard", real-time task updates, drill-down	Managers see completion live across sites	**Match.** Add alerts for late or missed checks, plus an exception list instead of only a dashboard
Downloadable reports and BI integration	Exports and analytics	**Match.** Add a one-tap "inspector mode" record for a health inspector or EHO visit
Region → site → department → user hierarchy, tasks assigned by role	Fits multi-site organisations	**Match.** Keep it simple for 1–10 sites
International time zones, disabling tasks during closures or refurbishment	Running across sites and countries	**Match.** This is cheap to build and worth having from day one
Records who completed each check	Accountability	**Beat.** Add live-capture photos, server timestamps and a PIN per staff member on a shared tablet
Pricing not disclosed	Sold through Food Alert consultancy contracts	**Beat.** Publish prices per location with month-to-month terms
Not offered on the page: repairs and maintenance, employee handbook and policy sign-offs, staff training, shift handover log		**Your openings.** These are the modules Check65 doesn't sell as an app

Competitor comparison

Prices below are from 2026. "3P" means a third-party estimate rather than a price the vendor publishes, so treat those figures as indicative only.

Product (owner)	Market	Checklists & temps	Repairs/maintenance	Handbook/policies	HACCP / allergens	Sensors	Pricing	Main weakness for a 1–10 site independent
Check65 / Alert65 (Food Alert → Citation)	UK, EU, ME	Yes, offline, Bluetooth probes	Not in public feature list	Site safety policies, risk assessments	Strong (HACCP, allergen matrix, consultancy)	Bluetooth probes	Quote only (Food Alert)	Opaque pricing, consultancy-led sale, UK-centric
Trail (Access Group)	UK	Yes	No native work orders	Evo tier only (policy mgmt, documents)	Limited	n/a	£38 / £75 / £82.50 per site/mo, 12-month minimum (Trail). A secondary source lists tiers from £11 (Toolradar), so the figures conflict	Corrective actions paywalled at £75; lock-in
Culinary Key	UK	Yes	No	No	Food-safety focus	n/a	£33–£40 per site/mo, cancel anytime (Culinary Key)	Narrow scope

Product (owner)	Market	Checklists & temps	Repairs/maintenance	Handbook/policies	HACCP / allergens	Sensors	Pricing	Main weakness for a 1–10 site independent
FoodDocs	US, UK, EU	Yes	No	No	AI HACCP builder (Standard+), traceability (Pro)	Integrations at Enterprise	$99 / $199 / $299 per site/mo ($79–$250 annual), unlimited users (FoodDocs)	Reviewers call it cost-prohibitive for small operators (GetApp)
Jolt (Digi)	US	Yes, label printing	No	Training, comms	Partial	Yes	Quote. 3P: $207–$296/location/mo plus $500–600 setup (SoftwareFinder)	Price, contracts, slow app, support complaints
Crunchtime Ops (ex-Zenput, Squadle)	US	Yes	No native work orders	No	Partial	Paid add-on	Quote. 3P from about $40/mo (Operandio)	Built for chains on Crunchtime back-office
ComplianceMate (Ladle)	US	HACCP checklists	No	No	Yes	LoRaWAN	3P: $100–250/mo plus $2.5–4k hardware (US Tech Automations)	Hardware capex
Xenia	US	Yes, auto corrective actions, live-capture GPS photos	**Yes**, QR work orders	No	Limited	Some	Free for 5 users. $99–$199/mo for 15 users plus per-user fees (3P). This conflicts with the vendor's "flat per-location" claim (GetApp; Xenia)	Closest US analogue. Not restaurant-compliance-deep, no handbook
SafetyCulture	Global	Generic inspections	Actions	No	Templates	Yes	$24–29 per user/mo (SoftwareSuggest)	Per-user pricing punishes high-turnover staff
Connecteam	Global	Ops Hub	No	Separate Comms/HR hubs	No	No	$29–99/mo per hub (3P) (actiTIME)	Hubs priced separately; not food-safety aware
7shifts / Homebase	US	Task add-on	No	Homebase HR	No	No	Task add-on about $13 per location/mo (GetApp; Capterra)	Shallow tasks; sets a low price anchor
MaintainX / UpKeep	Global	Work-order checklists	**Strong CMMS**	No	No	Some	$20–65 per user/mo (Capterra)	Not restaurant-specific; per-user

No product in the table bundles all four pillars. Xenia comes closest in the US with checklists, work orders and corrective actions but no handbook. Trail Evo comes closest in the UK with checklists, policies and documents but no work orders. Operators otherwise stitch together combinations such as Jolt plus MaintainX plus Homebase. That integration gap is the product thesis. The weaker version of the thesis is that "all-in-one" is easy to claim and hard to make excellent, which is why the differentiators section below focuses on the specific workflow that links the modules rather than on module count.

Operators buy speed and proof, and churn over slow apps, flaky probes and lock-in

Reviews are consistent across vendors. Jolt holds 4.6 on Capterra, yet its users report that the app "can be quite unreliable; it is slow and sometimes freezes up." They also describe onboarding as "overwhelming," call pricing "much higher than its competitors," and warn others to change contract terms "so they aren't locking you in for services that don't work" (Capterra; Software Advice). Crunchtime Ops reviewers cite slow image uploads, a mobile experience weaker than desktop, Bluetooth problems and "expensive hardware on top of monthly subscriptions." They also ask for more custom reporting and bulk export (G2). SafetyCulture users say value depends on staff actually completing photos and notes, otherwise managers end up "chasing things up" (Capterra). For 7shifts, a competitor-authored analysis attributes **64%** of negative reviews to bugs and **56%** to unreliable or overwhelming notifications (Connecteam). Treat that source with caution. Praise follows a pattern too: replacing paper, knowing who did what and when, and "the checklist feature saved us from chaos."

The deeper problem is **pencil-whipping**, meaning checklists and temperature logs completed without doing the work. Time pressure drives it, along with weak training and the belief that "no one's ever gotten sick" or that nobody reads the logs (Crunchtime; Ladle). Incumbents counter it with hardware, but hardware is also the top source of complaints, because Bluetooth and Wi-Fi struggle through stainless steel and insulated cold units (Refrigerated & Frozen Foods). A product that makes faking difficult with software alone has a real opening. Software alone here means live-capture photos, server timestamps, detection of identical repeated readings, and checklists that auto-close.

The economics justify the pain. The typical US operator spends a **median $22,500 a year on equipment repair and maintenance** (Bar & Restaurant / 86 Repairs). Almost half of reach-in refrigerator service calls are for units **"running too warm"** (86 Repairs). A single walk-in freezer circuit-board failure cost **$23,800**, of which $22,000 was spoiled stock (HSB/Munich Re). The CDC attributes **41% of restaurant outbreaks** with an identified cause to ill or infectious workers and **10.6% to improper cooling** (ABC7 on CDC). Hourly turnover runs about **92–110%**, with replacement costing about **$2,706 per hourly worker and $17,651 per GM** (Netchex). That turnover rate is why onboarding, handbook acknowledgement and microtraining belong in the same app. Frontline workers agree: **7 in 10 say app-based training would make learning easier** (Axonify via AAP). Shift handover is a further gap. Standalone manager-logbook apps such as Avero Logbook and Zip ShiftBook still exist, which shows that handover sits apart from checklists and maintenance today (App Store).

One gap in the research matters. Reddit and forum threads could not be retrieved, so the voice of independent operators comes from review sites and vendor blogs. Before building, the founder should do 20–30 operator interviews and read r/restaurantowners and r/KitchenConfidential directly.

Regulations reward contemporaneous, reviewable records, and the thresholds vary by jurisdiction

The most important design implication is that **thresholds must never be hard-coded**. In the US the FDA Food Code is a model code that binds a restaurant only once its state or locality adopts it. The current edition is the 2022 Food Code plus a **Supplement published 4 Nov 2024**. The Supplement adds disinfection provisions, food-defense awareness, sushi-rice acidification guidance, and formal definitions of **Food Safety Management System and Active Managerial Control**, including when an FSMS is required (FDA). That last change positions a digital verification tool as the operator's documented FSMS. The core loggable rules are as follows. The danger zone is 41–135°F. Two-stage cooling runs **135→70°F within 2 h, then 70→41°F within a further 4 h** (ICN). Date marking holds ready-to-eat TCS food **7 days at ≤41°F, counting prep day as day 1** (CDC). Sesame has been the 9th major allergen since 1 Jan 2023 (Fox13). **FSMA 204 traceability will not be enforced before 20 July 2028**.

When it is, records must be producible as an electronic sortable spreadsheet, with small-business exemptions (CSP Daily News; FDA).

UK law requires a permanent HACCP-based procedure with records "commensurate with the nature and size" of the business under retained Reg 852/2004 Art 5 (legislation.gov.uk). The FSA's Safer Food, Better Business pack **explicitly allows an electronic diary** kept until the next officer visit (GOV.UK). The FHRS 0–5 score includes a "management systems" element that rewards visible, reviewed records. Display of the score is mandatory in Wales and Northern Ireland (GOV.UK). Holding chilled food above **8°C** or hot food for service below **63°C** is an offence (SI 2013/2996). FSA guidance from March 2025 says **written allergen information should always be available** for non-prepacked food. That is best practice rather than statute (FSA).

Workplace rules feed the handbook and maintenance modules. US restaurants are **partially exempt from OSHA 300 logs**, but every employer must report fatalities, in-patient hospitalizations, amputations and eye loss (OSHA). Harassment training is state-driven: California requires training every 2 years for employers with 5+ staff, New York annual interactive training, and **Illinois restaurant-specific training in English and Spanish** (ASE). In the UK the Employment Rights Act 2025 has, since April 2026, required **6 years of holiday-pay records**. From **30 Oct 2026** it adds a duty to take "all reasonable steps" against sexual harassment, including by third parties. Shift-notice and cancellation-pay rules follow in 2027 (VinciWorks). The UK also requires a written fire risk assessment for every business since Oct 2023 (Pilla) and annual Gas Safe CP42 checks on commercial catering gas (Hillingdon Council).

Requirement-to-feature map, with verification status

Rows marked **[verify]** come from the researcher's background knowledge or a single secondary source and were not confirmed against a primary source. Confirm them before building rule content or making marketing claims.

Requirement	Jurisdiction	Feature it drives	Status
Cold ≤41°F, hot ≥135°F, two-stage cooling 2h/4h	US (Food Code, where adopted)	Temp logs with pass/fail and cooling timer	Sourced. **Per-state adoption and editions [verify]**: FDA adoption table returned 404; some states differ (e.g. CalCode, NYC)
7-day date marking, day 1 = prep	US	Prep labels and discard alerts	Sourced
FSMS / Active Managerial Control definitions	US (2024 Supplement)	Position app as the FSMS	Sourced
Cooking temps (165/155/145°F), reheat 165°F	US	Cook-temp checks	**[verify]**
Certified Food Protection Manager; Person in Charge present	US	Certificate tracking, PIC on shift	**[verify]**
Employee illness reporting ("Big 6"), vomit/diarrhea cleanup procedure	US	Illness/exclusion log, Form 1-B-style acknowledgement	**[verify]** (the CDC outbreak driver is sourced)
HACCP/variance for sous vide, curing, sushi rice; TPHC written procedures	US	HACCP plan builder, TPHC timers	**[verify]**
FSMA 204 receiving KDEs, 2-yr retention, 24-h production, ≤$250k exemption	US	Receiving log, sortable export	Enforcement date sourced; **specifics [verify]**
21 CFR Part 11 not applicable to routine restaurant logs	US	Avoid over-engineering e-signatures	**[verify]**
OSHA severe-injury reporting windows (8 h / 24 h)	US	Incident log prompts	Duty sourced; **windows [verify]**
NFPA 96 hood cleaning, NFPA 10 extinguishers, HazCom/SDS	US	Maintenance cadences, SDS library	**[verify]**
State harassment training (CA, NY, IL, CT, DE, ME)	US	State-aware training assignment	Sourced
I-9 retention, food handler cards (CA, IL, TX, WA, OR)	US	Document and certificate vault	**[verify]**
HACCP-based procedure, proportionate records; SFBB e-diary	UK	SFBB-style daily diary and 4-weekly review	Sourced. **SFBB pack contents (4-weekly review, 75°C probe check) [verify]**

Requirement	Jurisdiction	Feature it drives	Status
>8°C / <63°C offences	UK	Unit-aware thresholds	Sourced
14 allergens, written allergen info (FSA 2025)	UK	Per-dish allergen matrix with versioning	Guidance sourced; **14-allergen list and Natasha's Law (PPDS labels) [verify]**
Written fire risk assessment; CP42 gas; TR19 ducts; legionella 5-yr records; RIDDOR 3-yr	UK	Certificates and contractor-visit scheduler	Secondary sources. **Cadences (EICR 5 yrs, LOLER, PAT, extinguishers) [verify]**
ERA 2025: 6-yr holiday records, harassment duty 30 Oct 2026, 2027 shift rules	UK	Leave ledger, policy acknowledgements, shift change timestamps	Single secondary source. **Unfair-dismissal 6-month change [verify]** on GOV.UK
Right-to-work checks, day-1 written statement	UK	Onboarding checklist	**[verify]**
EU 2021/382 food safety culture; FSANZ 3.2.2A; Canadian provincial rules; Philippines PD 856	International	Future rules packs	**All [verify]**

The product conclusion is a **jurisdiction rules profile** that sets units, holding limits, date-marking days, required logs and certificate cadences per site. Rules content should be shipped as versioned, reviewable "rules packs" rather than code. A food-safety professional should sign off each pack before launch in that jurisdiction.

Recommended beachhead: US independent groups of 2–10 locations, with a free single-site tier

The bottom-up market is meaningful but not huge. About **749k US restaurants** exist, and **~70% are single-location operators** (Orbital). Independents and small multi-unit operators hold about two-thirds of sales, roughly $740B (NRN). At $40–150 per location per month, US checklist and food-safety software is worth roughly **$360M–1.35B a year**. Great Britain's ~99k licensed venues (NielsenIQ/CGA), plus cafés and takeaways, add an estimated £55–225M. These are inferences built from location counts and price points. Top-down analyst figures are not reliable here.

The recommended beachhead is **US independent restaurant groups with 2–10 locations**: full-service, fast-casual and café groups, ideally already on Toast or Square. Single-site operators come in through a free tier. The reasoning runs as follows. Multi-site owners feel the "I can't be everywhere" pain most acutely, so they value dashboards, corrective-action follow-through and handbook consistency, and they pay per location. Consolidation has pulled every dedicated vendor toward chains and franchisors, leaving this group underserved. US mid-market pricing is quote-based with implementation fees, so **transparent self-serve pricing is itself a differentiator in the US**. In the UK, Trail and Culinary Key already publish £33–£82.50 per-site prices. The UK is attractive second because SFBB explicitly accepts electronic diaries and the ERA 2025 creates fresh handbook and records demand. Entering it first would mean competing with Check65's consultancy content, Trail's Access distribution and Culinary Key's £33 floor at the same time.

Two segments are deliberately deprioritized. Ghost kitchens have high churn (Sacra), and food trucks bring tiny revenue per account. Franchisees with 5–50 units are a strong **secondary wedge** reachable through franchisee associations, though brand mandates can override their choice. Chains and franchisors are the right *later* market, because a franchisor mandate is the cheapest acquisition once won. The playbook is Jolt reaching >$20M ARR on ~$21.6M raised (Business Wire; CB Insights).

The product: eight modules joined by one closed loop

Module plan, MVP versus later

Module	MVP (months 0–6)	Phase 2 (6–12)	Phase 3 (12–24)
1. Checklists & shift ops	Opening/closing/mid-shift/cleaning templates, scheduled and ad-hoc lists, role/station assignment, photo or number or yes/no/signature fields, conditional logic, auto-close and late flags, shared-device PIN kiosk mode, offline-first sync	Shift handover logbook (notes, 86'd items, incidents carried to next manager), recurring audits and scored walk-throughs	Brand-standard audits for franchise groups, cross-site benchmarking
2. Food safety logs	Cold/hot holding, receiving, cook and reheat temps, **two-stage cooling timer with 2h/6h alerts**, date-mark labels with discard reminders, pass/fail against the site's rules profile, mandatory corrective action on failure	Bluetooth probe support (one or two vetted models), employee illness/exclusion log, sanitizer concentration checks, TPHC timers	Optional LoRaWAN/cellular fridge sensors (resold, not built), FSMA 204 receiving KDEs and sortable export (before July 2028)
3. Repairs & maintenance	Equipment register (QR sticker per asset), one-tap issue reporting with photo, issue → work order, status, vendor contact, cost field	Preventive maintenance schedules, vendor directory with dispatch by SMS/email link (no vendor login), warranty and service history, spend by asset	Repair-versus-replace insights, auto-work-order from sensor alarms, vendor marketplace or 86 Repairs-style partners
4. Handbook & policies	Handbook builder from templates, versioning, **e-signed acknowledgements** with re-acknowledgement on change, searchable SOP library	State/country-aware policy packs (harassment, illness reporting, allergen policy), "Ask the handbook" AI answers grounded only in the operator's own documents	UK ERA 2025 evidence pack, multi-brand handbooks
5. People, training & certificates	Staff roster (import from Toast/7shifts/CSV), certificate vault with expiry alerts (food handler, CFPM/Level 2–3)	Microlearning (2–3 min lessons, quizzes), state-aware harassment training assignment, onboarding checklist (I-9 / right-to-work reminders)	Bilingual or multilingual content library, training-to-error correlation
6. Compliance records & inspector mode	Immutable audit trail (who/when/where, server time), one-tap "inspector mode" read-only view and PDF export by date range, daily/weekly sign-off	UK SFBB-style diary and 4-weekly review, HACCP plan builder (AI-drafted, human-approved), allergen matrix per dish with change history	Certificates and contractor-visit scheduler (fire, gas CP42, hood/duct, pest, extinguishers) with cadence rules
7. Manager dashboard & alerts	Per-site completion, failures, open corrective actions and work orders; smart notifications (escalate only if not done)	Multi-site leaderboard, weekly owner email digest, anomaly flags (identical repeated readings, completed-in-seconds lists)	AI weekly ops summary, POS-linked context (sales versus labor versus failed checks)
8. Platform	iOS, Android, web; English and Spanish UI; per-site rules profile; SSO-free email/phone login; CSV export	Toast and Square integrations (staff sync, locations), 7shifts/Homebase sync, Zapier/webhooks, API	Insurance-carrier data sharing (opt-in), additional languages and jurisdictions

Where it beats existing apps

The **first differentiator is the closed loop**. A fridge reads 46°F. The app requires a corrective action ("moved product, re-check in 30 min"). It auto-creates a work order on that specific asset from its QR record and texts the refrigeration vendor a link. It logs the visit cost against the unit's warranty, and it shows the whole chain in inspector mode. Xenia has work orders and corrective actions but no compliance depth or handbook. Trail has policies but no work orders. FoodDocs and Check65 have food-safety depth but no maintenance workflow. Linking these steps is where the $22,500 median repair spend and the $23,800 spoilage events become ROI the owner can see.

The **second is anti-pencil-whipping without mandatory hardware**. It uses live-capture-only photos with server timestamps and optional geofencing, flags for identical repeated readings and implausibly fast completion, auto-close at the deadline, and a "spot-check" prompt that asks a random item to be re-verified with a photo. Hardware becomes an upsell rather than a prerequisite. That directly answers the Bluetooth and printer complaints and the $2.5–4k sensor capex of ComplianceMate.

The **third is speed and resilience as product requirements**. Reviews show slow apps directly cause skipped checklists. Targets: under 2 seconds to open a checklist, under 1 second per item tap, full offline capture with

background sync, and photo upload in the background. A shared kitchen tablet with a 4-digit PIN per employee fits real kitchens better than individual logins.

The **fourth is time-to-value under 15 minutes**. The owner picks a concept type (café, full-service, fast casual, bar), a location (which sets the rules profile), and their equipment. The app generates a starter set of checklists, logs, a maintenance register and a handbook draft. AI drafting helps here, as FoodDocs does for HACCP plans (FoodDocs), but every AI output is a draft the operator approves.

The **fifth is commercial terms**. Unlimited users per location (SafetyCulture's per-user model punishes turnover), month-to-month with an annual discount, no implementation fee, and in-app chat support with a published response-time commitment. That counters the most emotional review complaints: lock-in and support that never fixes anything.

The **sixth is a bilingual frontline**. English and Spanish ship at launch, which Illinois already requires for restaurant harassment training. Per-user language settings come next, so the same checklist renders in each worker's language. The research flags multilingual demand as plausible but untested, so it is an open question as well as a feature.

AI belongs where POS platforms will not compete. Toast IQ already answers business questions and executes actions across ~148k locations (StockTitan), so a generic "AI assistant" is a losing position. The defensible AI features are compliance-specific: drafting HACCP plans, SOPs and handbooks from templates; answering staff questions grounded in the operator's own approved documents; grading photo evidence ("is the label present, is the line clean"); and summarizing the week's failures into an owner digest.

Price per location at $49–$119, sell through POS marketplaces and insurers

The research supports a US price window of **$40–$120 per location per month**. That sits above the ~$13 task add-ons from 7shifts and Homebase and below Jolt's quoted $207–$296 and FoodDocs Standard at $199 (FoodDocs; SoftwareFinder). The recommended structure is below. The specific price points are a recommendation for testing, not sourced figures.

Plan	Price (per location/mo)	Includes
Free	$0, 1 location	Checklists and temp logs, 30-day history, 1 manager, inspector-mode export
Core	~$49 monthly / ~$39 annual	Unlimited users and history, all food-safety logs with corrective actions, basic repairs and maintenance (register, issues, work orders), handbook with e-acknowledgements, certificate vault, dashboard
Pro	~$99 monthly / ~$79 annual	Preventive maintenance and vendor dispatch, warranty and spend tracking, training and microlearning, AI drafting and "ask the handbook," multi-site analytics, Toast/Square/7shifts integrations, probe support
Groups / franchise	Custom above ~10 sites	Brand-standard audits, SSO, API, rollout support
Hardware	Near cost, optional	Vetted Bluetooth probe; sensors via partner resale

In the UK, a later launch would price around **£35–£69 per site**. That lands between Culinary Key's £33–£40 floor and Trail's £75 Standard tier (Culinary Key).

Go-to-market should run on four channels. **Product-led self-serve** comes first: SEO content around "restaurant opening checklist," "cooling log template" and "health inspection checklist [state]," with free downloadable PDF templates converting into the free tier. **POS marketplaces** come second. Toast has ~180k locations and is expanding in the UK (Las Vegas Sun/Business Wire), and its integration marketplace is where its operators discover apps (Toast support). **Insurance partnerships** are the under-used third channel. Towergate gives Checkit users a **£60–£100 per location annual premium reduction** (The Caterer), and PathSpot has a similar US arrangement. That offsets 10–30% of a subscription and gives the owner a concrete reason to switch. **Local**

channels are fourth: state restaurant associations, food-safety trainers and consultants as resellers, and refrigeration and repair vendors who benefit from organized work orders.

Phased roadmap

Phase	Timing	Goal	Exit criteria
0. Validate	Weeks 0–8	25–30 operator interviews (2–10 site independents), clickable prototype, rules-pack review by a food-safety professional for one or two launch states	10 design partners committed; clear top-3 jobs confirmed
1. MVP	Months 2–6	Checklists, food-safety logs with corrective actions, basic repairs and maintenance, handbook acknowledgements, inspector mode, offline mobile, EN/ES	Design partners use it daily at least 5 days a week for 8 weeks; at least one real inspection uses inspector mode
2. Paid launch	Months 6–12	Self-serve billing, Toast/Square/7shifts integrations, preventive maintenance and vendor dispatch, AI drafting, microlearning, probe support	150–300 paying locations; logo churn under 3% a month; first insurer pilot
3. Expand	Months 12–24	UK rules pack (SFBB diary, allergen matrix, certificates scheduler, ERA evidence), franchise features, sensor partner, FSMA 204 receiving	UK beta with 20+ sites; first 25+ location franchise group
4. Platform	24+ months	Benchmarking, vendor marketplace, insurer data products, more jurisdictions	Positioned for partnership or acquisition by POS, back-office or IoT buyer

Risks and open questions

The biggest structural risk is **customer fragility**. US independents fell 2.3% in 2025 to ~412.5k units (NRN), and closures alone will churn accounts. Generic B2B churn benchmarks of 5–10% a year are not restaurant-specific (LiveX), so plan for worse. The mitigation is the accumulated audit record, which is the switching cost, plus integrations and multi-site accounts. The second risk is **platform encroachment**. Toast, Square or 7shifts could deepen their task modules, and Toast IQ already acts across locations. The mitigation is compliance depth and the maintenance loop, both of which sit outside POS data, and integrating with POS platforms rather than competing with them. The third risk is **exit economics**. Jolt sold at ~7x ARR to a strategic buyer, and Trail, Zenput and Squadle went to suites (Business Wire). That argues for capital-efficient growth over venture-scale burn. The fourth is **regulatory liability**. If the app's thresholds are wrong for a jurisdiction, an operator could fail an inspection or cause harm. The mitigations are reviewed rules packs, visible rule sources, operator confirmation at setup, and clear terms that the operator remains responsible. The fifth is **scope creep**. Eight modules is a lot for a small team, which is why the MVP takes a thin slice of each pillar and makes it excellent rather than shipping every module broad.

The plan depends on answers the research could not supply. These should drive the validation phase:

Open question	Why it matters	How to test
Is the founder US- or UK-based, and where are early customers reachable?	Beachhead choice assumes US first	Founder decision
Do 2–10 site owners pay $49–$99/location for the bundle, or only for food safety?	Core pricing thesis	Price-sensitivity interviews; fake-door pricing page
Which pillar is the true buying trigger: inspections, repairs, or staff turnover?	Determines MVP emphasis and messaging	Interview ranking exercise; landing-page A/B
How often do inspectors actually ask to see logs, and do they accept app records?	Inspector-mode value. UK SFBB accepts e-diaries; US practice is **[verify]**	Talk to 5–10 health inspectors/EHOs
Is software-only anti-falsification good enough, or do buyers insist on probes and sensors?	Hardware strategy	Design-partner pilots with and without probes
How much do multilingual checklists matter in practice?	EN/ES launch cost	Staff language survey at design partners
Will US insurers offer premium credits for documented compliance?	Channel economics	Outreach to 3–5 BOP/restaurant carriers
Which per-state Food Code editions and local variants apply in launch states?	Rules-pack correctness **[verify]**	State health department review

Open question	Why it matters	How to test
What do operators actually say on Reddit and forums?	Research gap: no forum data retrieved	Manual review of r/restaurantowners, r/KitchenConfidential
Real churn, CAC and sales-cycle data for this category	No sourced benchmarks	Track from day one; ask advisors from Jolt, Zenput or Trail alumni

Conclusion

The research changes the framing of "build something like Check65." Check65 is a consultancy's distribution arm, and copying its feature list would put a startup into a contest with 30 years of UK regulatory content. The winnable product is something no incumbent has built for small operators: one fast, trustworthy record of what happened in the restaurant today, plus what broke, who fixed it, what it cost, and whether the staff knew the rules. Consolidation has made this gap wider over time. Every successful checklist vendor has been absorbed into a suite that sells to chains, which leaves the independent multi-site owner as the customer whose money is uncontested.

The strategic implication is to treat compliance as the wedge and maintenance as the moat. Food-safety logs get the app installed because inspectors and regulations demand them. The repairs and maintenance loop is the part the owner reads, because that is where the $22,500 a year and the $23,800 freezer failure live, and over time it builds an asset history that is painful to abandon. Build it capital-efficiently and integrate with POS platforms rather than fighting them, because the likeliest successful outcome is a strategic acquisition by one of those platforms.